Moreover, temporary rollbacks of authority may evolve into long-term compromises that weaken the institution's effectiveness and relevance. IOs must therefore navigate these trade-offs carefully. While temporary leniency may help maintain states' engagement, overuse of this strategy risks alienating other members and eroding the organization's credibility.

7.1.3 Direct Rhetorical Appeals

A third approach to combating populist hostility is directly appealing to domestic audiences. Historically, IOs have focused on disseminating information to elite audiences through press releases, research papers, and technical reports (Clemens and Kremer 2016; Goes and Chapman 2024). However, the rise of social media has transformed how IOs communicate, allowing them to bypass traditional channels and engage directly with the public.

Unlike press releases or policy briefs, social media enables IOs to tailor messages to specific audiences, particularly those skeptical of IOs. By emphasizing their alignment with ordinary people and highlighting the tangible benefits they provide, IOs can counter populist narratives that paint them as out-of-touch elites. For instance, IMF officials have rebranded the organization as a defender of "the people" during financial crises, and WTO staff have emphasized their advocacy for everyday citizens.[7]

This strategy is particularly appealing because it is low-cost and scalable. Unlike targeted aid or relaxed constraints, rhetorical appeals do not require significant financial resources or institutional compromises. Moreover, they avoid the equity and legitimacy concerns that can arise from selective leniency or aid distribution. Instead, they foster transparency and inclusivity.

While all three methods of appeasement are important, this chapter concentrates on IOs' rhetorical strategies, particularly their use of social media. This focus allows us to explore a cost-effective and widely available approach that has become increasingly central to IOs' public engagement efforts. Through social media, IOs can reach mass audiences, counter populist narratives, and enhance their legitimacy in an era of growing skepticism toward international cooperation.